

FOUNDING VOLUME — EST. 2026

Why is the institution producing this outcome?

An interdisciplinary journal at UCLA studying how governments, courts, schools, and agencies actually work — and how they can be reformed to serve the public better.

SUBMIT YOUR WORK

JOIN THE FOUNDING TEAM

§01 Why This Journal

Every day, we encounter debates about immigration, reproductive healthcare, education, artificial intelligence, civil rights, criminal justice, climate policy, and countless other issues that shape public life. Behind each of these debates lies something larger: the

institutions responsible for implementing laws, delivering services, protecting rights, and serving the public.

Institutions are the systems through which societies govern, educate, protect, regulate, and care for their communities. They include governments, courts, schools, universities, hospitals, law enforcement agencies, foster care systems, nonprofit organizations, and international organizations. These institutions influence nearly every aspect of society by determining how justice is administered, how children are protected, how elections are conducted, how healthcare is delivered, and how governments respond to emerging challenges. Yet while public discourse often centers on political disagreement or individual actors, less attention is given to the institutional structures that produce these outcomes.

While these discussions are important, they often overlook a more fundamental question:



Why is the institution producing these outcomes in the first place?

To answer that question, we must look beyond individual actors and examine the systems themselves. Institutional performance is shaped by governance, legal frameworks, incentives, oversight, organizational culture, funding, and implementation.

Understanding these structural mechanisms allows us not only to explain why institutions succeed or fail, but also to identify reforms capable of strengthening them.

The Institutional Review was founded to create an interdisciplinary

forum where students from diverse academic backgrounds can collaborate to study institutional performance and develop evidence-informed reforms. By bridging disciplines and applying a shared framework of institutional analysis, we seek to move beyond describing problems toward understanding their structural causes and proposing practical solutions that strengthen institutions and better serve the public.

§02 Vision Statement

The Institutional Review envisions a society in which institutions are accountable, transparent, and continually challenged to better serve the public. Our goal is to confront institutional injustice by strengthening the public's capacity to evaluate institutions and demand systems that protect rights, respond to wrongdoing, and advance more equitable outcomes.

Our Approach

We believe meaningful reform begins with understanding why institutions produce the outcomes they do. Rather than focusing solely on individual actors or isolated events, our scholarship examines the structural mechanisms that shape institutional performance.

Every publication follows a shared framework of institutional analysis, asking five fundamental questions:

01 What is the problem?

02 Why does it exist?

03 What institutional mechanisms contribute to it?

04 What reforms could address it?

05 What outcomes should those reforms achieve?

§03 What We Publish

The Institutional Review publishes interdisciplinary scholarship that examines how institutions shape people's lives, why they produce unequal or ineffective outcomes, and how they can be reformed to better serve the public.

Our contributors begin with issues they care deeply about — human rights, immigration, reproductive healthcare, civil rights, education, foster care, criminal justice, technology, public health, environmental protection, and beyond — and investigate the institutions responsible for shaping those outcomes.

A student concerned about reproductive healthcare might examine how hospital policies, state regulations, insurance structures, and medical oversight affect access to care. A contributor interested in immigration might study how court backlogs, administrative

discretion, legal representation, and detention systems influence due process. A student focused on child welfare might analyze how licensing rules, reporting systems, funding incentives, and oversight structures affect the safety of children in institutional care.

Although these subjects differ, every publication is connected by a shared purpose: to move beyond identifying injustice and toward understanding the systems that sustain it. We seek scholarship that asks:

- What institution holds responsibility for the issue?
- What purpose is that institution supposed to serve?
- Why is it producing its current outcomes?
- Which laws, incentives, governance structures, or administrative practices contribute to those outcomes?
- What reforms could produce a more just and effective system?

Our goal is to give students the opportunity to transform their academic interests and lived concerns into rigorous, constructive research. Contributors will not simply comment on public problems — they will learn to investigate institutional structures, evaluate evidence, compare alternative models, and develop practical recommendations for reform.

LONG-FORM **Institutional Case Studies**

The Journal's principal form of long-form scholarship. Each study focuses on a specific institution or system and examines the gap between its intended purpose and its actual performance — identifying

the people affected, analyzing the structural causes of institutional outcomes, and proposing legal, administrative, or organizational reforms.

Residential treatment oversight

Immigration court administration

Access to reproductive healthcare

Foster care monitoring

Civil-rights enforcement

Public-school discipline

Prison oversight

University accountability

Election administration

AI governance

Environmental regulation

Public-health infrastructure

ACTIONABLE Policy Briefs

Rather than examining an entire institution, a Policy Brief addresses one specific institutional problem and proposes a defined response — clear, accessible, and useful to audiences beyond the university.

Reporting systems for children in institutional care

Immigration-court case management

Agency transparency requirements

Safeguards for reproductive-health data

University complaint procedures

Oversight for automated decision-making

CROSS-SYSTEM Comparative Analyses

Comparative Analyses examine how different institutions respond to similar challenges — states, countries, historical periods, agencies, universities, courts, or healthcare systems. The goal isn't to declare one system better, but to identify the structural features that produce

different outcomes.

Foster-care oversight, state by state

Election administration across democracies

Equitable access to reproductive care

Civilian-oversight body authority

Regulating emerging technologies

Human-rights enforcement safeguards

§04 A Place for Interdisciplinary Inquiry

The Journal is not limited to one political ideology, academic department, or area of law. Institutional problems rarely belong to a single discipline. A strong publication may draw from:



We are building a publication where students from different backgrounds can bring distinct forms of knowledge to a shared question: how can institutions become more accountable, more just, and more capable of serving the people whose lives they shape?

Every contributor should be able to see an issue they care about

reflected in this work, and recognize that they have the ability to investigate it, challenge it, and help imagine a better institutional future.

§05 **Build Something That Lasts**

The institutions we inherit need not be the institutions we leave behind. Join us in building a future shaped by thoughtful scholarship, meaningful accountability, and the continued pursuit of justice.

Your Role in the Mission

Every enduring institution begins with a small group of people willing to ask difficult questions and build something larger than themselves. As a founding member of The Institutional Review, you will have the opportunity to shape the Journal's culture, establish its traditions, and contribute to a publication designed to continue long after its founding class graduates.

Whether your interests lie in human rights, immigration, environmental policy, education, public health, artificial intelligence, criminal justice, housing, or another area of public concern, there is a place for your perspective within this Journal. We are not seeking students who already have all the answers — we are seeking students who are intellectually curious, committed to rigorous scholarship, and passionate about strengthening the

institutions that shape public life.

Who We're Looking For

Every person brings a different story, a different perspective, and a different way of understanding the world. Those differences are not simply welcomed — they are essential to our mission. Perhaps you have witnessed a problem firsthand and want to understand why it exists. Perhaps you've spent years studying an issue that matters deeply to you. Whatever has brought you here, your perspective has the potential to ask questions that no one else can.

You do not need to be an expert. You do not need publishing experience. You simply need curiosity, a willingness to learn, and the belief that thoughtful research can contribute to a more accountable and just society. If there is an issue you care about, there is a place for you here.

§06 Join the Founding Team

The Institutional Review is more than a publication — it's an opportunity to establish a lasting community of students committed to rigorous scholarship, institutional accountability, and the continued pursuit of justice. As a founding member, you will help shape not only the Journal's first publication, but also the traditions, standards, and culture that will guide future generations of contributors.

We are seeking students who are excited to help build this organization from the ground up. Whether your strengths lie in leadership, writing, research, editing, organization, or design, every role plays an essential part in advancing our mission.

The Editorial Board meets weekly or biweekly, depending on submission volume, to move pieces through review.

Executive Director

Leads the long-term vision and strategic development of the Journal — guiding the organization's growth, building relationships across campus, and ensuring every initiative remains faithful to our mission. *Weekly:* checks in with the Editor-in-Chief, tracks recruitment and outreach, and handles department/faculty-advisor administration.

Editor-in-Chief

Oversees the Journal's scholarly vision and editorial excellence, working closely with authors and editors to ensure every publication reflects our standards of rigorous institutional analysis and evidence-informed reform. *Weekly:* reviews submissions in final-stage review, runs the editorial meeting, and makes accept/reject decisions on pieces that clear peer review.

Managing Editor

Coordinates the publication process from submission to release — keeping projects moving, supporting the editorial team, and ensuring every issue is published efficiently and professionally. *Weekly:* triages new submissions, assigns reviewing editors, and tracks where every piece sits in the pipeline.

Research & Methodology Director

Safeguards the Journal's commitment to rigorous scholarship, supporting writers in developing strong research, applying the Institutional Analysis Framework, and producing evidence-informed recommendations. *Weekly*: reviews submissions for evidence quality and framework adherence, and holds office hours for contributors.

Publications & Digital Director

Shapes how the Journal is experienced by the public — designing each issue and maintaining the website and digital archive so our scholarship is presented with professionalism and lasting impact. *Weekly*: updates the site as pieces are accepted, formats accepted work for publication, and manages promotion.

Section Editors — Case Studies, Policy Briefs, Comparative Analyses

Give contributors in their category a first-pass review and feedback, keeping the specific character of each publication type intact. *Weekly*: reviews new submissions in their section and returns feedback to contributors within a week.

FOUNDING COMMITMENT

Leadership within the Journal is both a privilege and a responsibility. Every Executive Board member contributes not only to the organization's operation but also to its scholarship. Founding leaders are expected to:

- Publish at least one original article, policy brief, or institutional case study each academic quarter.
- Participate in the editorial review process.

- Mentor and support fellow contributors.
- Uphold the Journal's mission, methodology, and standards of scholarship.
- Help shape an organization designed to continue serving UCLA long after its founding members graduate.

§07 Submit Your Work

No prior publishing experience required. Paste your manuscript below, or link to a Google Doc if you'd rather share it that way — we'll follow up by email.

FULL NAME

EMAIL

YEAR & MAJOR

SUBMISSION TYPE

Institutional Case Study 

WORKING TITLE

ABSTRACT (2-4 SENTENCES)

MANUSCRIPT TEXT – OR PASTE A GOOGLE DOC SHARE LINK

Paste your draft, or a link like <https://docs.google.com/>...

SUBMIT FOR REVIEW

Submissions go straight to the editorial team's inbox for review.

***If there is a system you believe can be improved, we
want to help you investigate it.***

